Position Player Comparison

SABR Level One | Daniel Hedrick

For this player comparison, I am going with player A, and for me it isn't remotely close.

To follow the modules model, I will start off with the baseline knowledge, player A is only 26 currently in this comparison. To put that into perspective, he is younger than Ben Rice is currently, who just put up a 149 wRC+ season. Essentially what you are telling me here is, you have a player who has already surpassed that season at the plate, and unlike Rice and a lot of other young first basemen, he is actually competent (well above competent actually) and is able to stay at first base without needing much time at DH. Adding onto my support for “Player A” it doesn’t seem as if regression will hit him anytime soon, and it even seems as if he is experiencing good fortune that could’ve been predicted in his age 23 season with a .25 point gap between his average and BABIP, along with that each year his BABIP has shot up along with his average. Player A’s wOBA and xwOBA are close enough to each other, where I am not really worried about regression, along with that a .353 xwOBA puts player A right around Matt Olson range, and safely in the top 30 of major league hitters for 2026.

Not to seem like too much of a fan here, but I’d be confident giving player A a contract in 2 years, that surpasses the highest AAV (Vlad Guerrero Jr. at $36M) for a first baseman. As I have stated, he checks legitimately every single box you can ask for out of an elite first baseman. Player A provides value in the field and is above average in every stat you threw out there, 13 DRS is borderline elite. That means he most likely won’t clog up my DH spot that I can then utilize to acquire another bat for the lineup. This is further backed up by him playing 140+ games every season in the field. This player clearly has a rare set of skills and I would be pretty comfortable taking him over just about any other first basemen you could have thrown out there at me today.

I will briefly explain why I wouldn’t select player B, because it would be malpractice not To do my homework on both players. Player B is a solid player, clearly, but I would struggle to invest serious capital into him. First off, in his age 32 season we can already see an uptick in his starts at DH. It is pretty clear to see why this is -3 DRS, -7 OAA, -10.5 FRAA. This player isn’t a good fielder and that usually doesn’t improve with age. It is more than likely this player reserves an even bigger role at the DH spot going forward. Jose Abreu, I mean player B, as a first baseman with wRC+ numbers breaking 110 every year, isn’t someone I’d necessarily complain about having in the lineup, but first basemen across the league in 2026 had a 112 wRC+, seemingly cutting his value a bit.

I will finish up my analysis with a point that I have hit on multiple times throughout this Comparison. I value my flexibility at DH a ton. When you have players like Anthony Rizzo, I mean player A in your lineup it gives your front office the option to go out in free agency and target a guy who can DH for you for 90% of the year, where as if you have player B, maybe you aren’t as confident in your roster construction come winter time. Not to get off track, but this is going to be an issue for the Yankees this offseason, due to Rice's issues in the field, and it really is a prevalent issue come playoff time.

With all that being said, welcome to my team, Player A.

Comp Spreadsheet - Position Player Comparison Data - Module 13.xlsx

Comparison Data

Source: SABR course comparison spreadsheet, supplied with the evaluation. Ages represent the four seasons shown for each player.

Player A

Age	G	HR	AVG	OBP	SLG
23	160	23	0.233	0.323	0.419
24	140	32	0.286	0.386	0.527
25	160	31	0.278	0.387	0.512
26	155	32	0.292	0.385	0.544

Age	OPS+	wRC+	wOBA	xwOBA	fWAR	DRS
23	103	105	0.325		1.8	12
24	152	155	0.397		5.3	9
25	146	145	0.384	0.372	5.2	10
26	143	145	0.391	0.353	4.9	13

Player B

Age	G	HR	AVG	OBP	SLG
29	159	25	0.293	0.353	0.468
30	156	33	0.304	0.354	0.552
31	128	22	0.265	0.325	0.473
32	159	33	0.284	0.33	0.503

Age	OPS+	wRC+	wOBA	xwOBA	fWAR	DRS
29	124	121	0.349	0.339	2	-1
30	141	139	0.377	0.347	4.3	1
31	117	114	0.337	0.349	1.2	-1
32	118	115	0.344	0.354	1.7	-3